

society & the arts ANIMATED FILMS

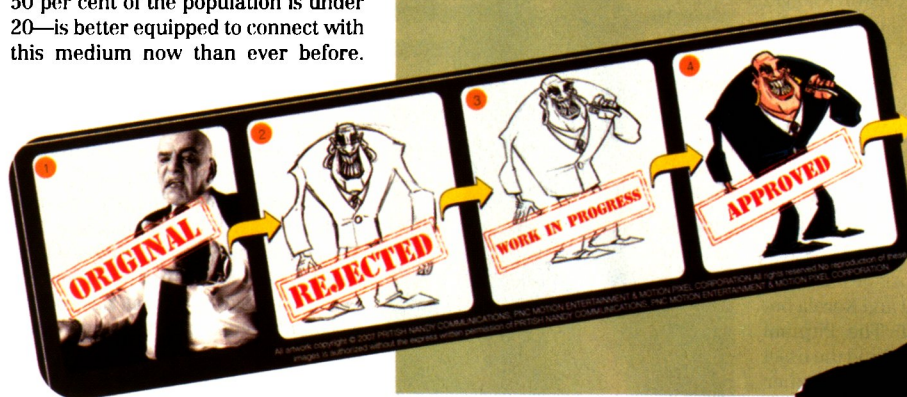
■ By Malini Bhupta

If Rajnikanth's antics in *Sivaji The Boss* had you hooked and Mallika Sherawat's lissome act in *Pyar Ke Side Effects* left you gasping, brace yourself for animated versions of these actors next year. Bollywood has boarded the fantasy bandwagon to wonderland, where Hanuman can go to school and an animated Shah Rukh Khan can romance Kajol a la Archie in the remake of *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai*. All this comes without the starry tantrums of the lead characters. The director and script writer can bend the characters at will. From mythological heroes to sci-fi action, different types of stories are on the drawing boards, with animation not being limited by the impossible.

Traditionally, animation has not been big business in India. Of course, young India—where the average age of 50 per cent of the population is under 20—is better equipped to connect with this medium now than ever before.

TOON BOOM

Bollywood boards the fantasy bandwagon as animation films using mythology, sci-fi and mainstream stars are set to hit screens next year



Unlike previous generations, today's youth has been brought up on animation films like *Shrek* and *Finding Nemo*. The turning point for the genre came with the resounding success of *Hanuman* in 2004, which paved the way for biggies like Adlabs, UTV and Yash Raj Films to enter the fray. The Rs 10-crore film collected over Rs 30 crore at the box office and earned another Rs 6.5 crore via sales of satellite, home video and merchandising rights. Says Preet Bedi, CEO of Percept Picture Company (PPC), an entertainment house, "While technology has helped infuse faster movement in animation, visualising an entire film on sheets is not so easy. Good creative skill remains a bottleneck."

Indian studios are now competent

enough to produce sophisticated creative content with their technical prowess. Animation in India is a sunrise sector, with the industry's outsourcing revenues of Rs 1,317 crore expected to touch Rs 3,700 crore by 2010. With the domestic market booming, the sector is all set to move up the value chain and produce sophisticated original content.

Animation studios like the Indian subsidiary of Los Angeles-based Rhythm and Hues have already done technical films like *Chronicles of Narnia: The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe*. The parent company created the visual effects and animation for the film, while its Mumbai subsidiary worked simultaneously on digitally mixing the computer-generated

imagery with live action footage, and was also involved in post-production work. Animation studios say it is 30-40 per cent cheaper to outsource such work to studios in India, as animation requires heavy investment in technology.

The minimum cost of making a good animation film is Rs 15-20 crore. It takes much longer to make an animation film, as every frame has to be drawn and then animated, making the director's job difficult. Says Suparn Verma, director of *EKEH 2.0*, a remake of *Ek Khiladi Ek Hasina*, "When you make an animation film, you are as limited as your imagination. An animated version of a live action film is bigger and better in every way."

That's what Anubhav Sinha's film